

AI Critical Analysis of “Evolution of Judeo-Christian Deity”

Requested by Aaron J Powner 2026

The full title of the essay being analyzed is “Evolution of Judeo-Christian Deity: Critical Analysis of the Historical Shift from *El Shaddai* and the Divine Council to the Geopolitical Consolidation to Creedal Monotheism” by Aaron J Powner, unpublished.

The theological landscape of the ancient Near East and its subsequent influence on modern monotheistic orthodoxy presents a complex tapestry of linguistic evolution, cosmological shifts, and political consolidation. The following analysis evaluates the core ideas of the "unified species" hypothesis, the historical mechanics of "pantheon reduction," and the tension between orthopraxy and imperial orthodoxy.

1. The Sociological Shift: From Patriarchal Tribalism to the Legalistic Nation-State

The hypothesis that the shift from *El Shaddai* to *Jehovah* mirrors the transition from tribal, patriarchal religion to a centralized nation-state religion is strongly supported by historical-critical scholarship.¹

- **Strengths:** This idea aligns with archaeological evidence of Israel's emergence as a "settler colonial agrarian frontier society" that eventually consolidated under the Davidic and Josianic monarchies. During the tribal era, religion was decentralized and familial—invoking the "God of the Fathers" for protection and progeny. The Josianic reforms (7th century BCE) centralized all sacrificial worship in Jerusalem, effectively making the high priest and king the sole mediators of divine power.³
- **Weaknesses:** Some conservative scholars, such as Michael Heiser, argue that this view relies on an evolutionary presupposition that denies the continuity of revelation.⁵ They posit that *Jehovah* (Yahweh) and *El* were identified as the same being early on, and that the shift in naming reflects an experiential disclosure of God's "character" (the Promise Keeper) rather than a sociological adaptation.⁶

2. The Divine Council and the "Literal Handoff" of Responsibilities

Ancient Israelite religion was characterized by henotheism or monolatry, acknowledging a "Divine Council" (*sôd Elohim*) where the High God (*El/Elyon*) presided over a bustling assembly of spiritual beings.⁸

- **Strengths:** Modern research into Ugaritic and Aramaic cognates confirms that the ancient Hebrews viewed the heavens as a familial assembly.⁸ This supports the "Two Powers in Heaven" tradition, which suggests that speculating about a second divine figure (the *Logos* or a supreme agent) was not considered heretical until the 2nd century CE. Theologically, this provides a framework for Jehovah acting as the "Word made Flesh" to fulfill the duties of the Messiah on Earth.
- **Weaknesses:** The specific LDS interpretation of a "literal handoff" between God the Father and a pre-mortal Jehovah is a minority view in broader biblical studies. Traditional Christians often interpret Psalm 82's "gods" as human judges or a rhetorical device to mock fallen spiritual beings, rather than a depiction of a co-equal or subordinate divine hierarchy.

3. The Law as a Tutor: From Abrahamic Orthopraxy to Pharisaic Orthodoxy

The hypothesis that the Law of Moses served as a "strict tutor" meant to prepare a "stiff-necked people" for the Law of the Gospel finds significant grounding in New Testament theology and historical development.

- **Strengths:** This idea explains the historical shift from the relational, faith-based "Promise Stage" of Abraham to the legalistic, "Fulfillment Stage" of the Mosaic era.⁶ The eventual decay of this system into the "Woes of the Pharisees" is seen as the natural result of centuries of imperial politics and institutional traditionalism, which replaced spiritual light with rigid external conformity.
- **Weaknesses:** This view can lead to a "replacement theology" that oversimplifies the Mosaic Covenant. Traditional Jewish and some Christian perspectives maintain that the Law was never meant to be *supplanted* but was inherently a vehicle for grace and a heart-based relationship with God.

4. Pantheon Reduction and the Mechanism of Political Consolidation

The historical process of "pantheon reduction" is often viewed not as a theological maturation but as a political tool for consolidating imperial power.⁸

- **Strengths:** The centralization of religion under the Sassanian kings of Iran and the later Islamic Caliphates mirrors the establishment of post-apostolic Christian orthodoxy through political creeds. By defining God as an immaterial, singular essence (e.g., at Nicaea), imperial authorities could regulate the individual's relationship with the Divine and consolidate power in the hands of a theological nobility.
- **Weaknesses:** Pro-creedal defenders argue that these theological clarifications were necessary to protect members' salvation from chaotic and destructive "heresies" like Arianism, which they believed undermined the efficacy of the Atonement. From this

perspective, orthodoxy is a safeguard rather than a tool of tyranny.

5. The Primacy of Orthopraxy and Ethical Integrity

The command in Genesis 17 to "walk before me, and be blameless" suggests that right action (orthopraxy) is the ultimate objective of the mortal journey.⁸

- **Strengths:** Christ’s teachings frequently prioritize ethical integrity and "right practice" over legalistic adherence to the Law of Moses.³ The "unified species" hypothesis strengthens this by recognizing the potential for "eternal progression" in all human beings, emphasizing that our shared divine nature demands moral agency and growth.
- **Weaknesses:** Critiques of this hypothesis argue that orthopraxy cannot be separated from orthodoxy; without "right belief," correct action can degenerate into generic social work without spiritual grounding or purpose. Many theologians insist that "correct doctrine" (orthodoxy) is the necessary prerequisite that leads to "correct behavior" (orthopraxy).

Summary of Theoretical Perspectives

Perspective	View on Godhead	Focus of Religious Life
Traditional Trinitarian	Incomprehensible, immaterial essence.	Orthodoxy; adhering to the creeds as a test of faith. ¹⁶
LDS / Restorationist	Unified species; God and humans share a nature. ¹⁷	Eternal Progression; orthopraxy and theosis. ¹⁹
Historical-Critical	Evolution from tribal henotheism to state monotheism. ¹	Sociological/political analysis of power structures. ²
Jewish Traditional	Singular, majestic God; relational covenant partner. ²⁰	Fulfillment of the Mitsvot (commandments) and legal fidelity. ²⁰

Question for Further Consideration: Who Created Whom?

This analysis leads to a fundamental philosophical crossroads:

1. **Revelatory Realism (Imago Dei):** This view holds that God created mankind in His literal image for the purpose of eternal progression. Within this framework, humans are "gods in embryo," and the revelations of *El Shaddai* and *Jehovah* are steps in a divine education

meant to lead humanity back to its Source.⁸

2. **Projection Theory (Sociological Function):** Following thinkers like Ludwig Feuerbach and Karl Marx, this view posits that mankind created God in *his* image to serve the needs of power structures. In this model, "orthodoxy" and the "reduction of the pantheon" are psychological projections used to justify social order, preserve class systems, and pacify the masses with the hope of an afterlife.

Ultimately, while the political and sociological mechanisms of religion are observable in history, the individual pursuit of spiritual light remains a matter of moral agency—walking "blamelessly" before the Divine, however it is named.

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